The year 2023 has been rather eventful for Kareena Kapoor Khan in her newfound pursuit of artistic merit over mere stardom. By her own admission, Kareena wanted a "makeover" for what she was doing. "I am glad to have embarked on a new phase in my career, in which my focus has changed markedly. While I am eager to work, I am keen on stuff that excites me rather than acceding to what people want me to do," she says.

If her recent releases and forthcoming projects are anything to go by, Kareena is on a mission. In an age where following the latest trends is considered the mantra for success, Kareena took her own sweet time to get onto the OTT bandwagon. In fact, she made her OTT debut with *Jaane Jaan* in her 23rd year in the Hindi film industry. Point this out and she says, "I have always been like this—only doing work I want to do. I am grateful for the privilege, and I have also made some questionable choices. But mostly, it's been to do with whatever I wanted to do at that point of time."

Kareena also stars in Hansal Mehta's detective drama *The Buckingham Murders*, which premiered at the 67th BFI London Film Festival on October 14, was the opening film of the Jio MAMI Mumbai Film Festival on October 27 and is expected to release on Netflix soon. It's right out of the thriller genre that Kareena enjoys, even as a viewer. "If not done well, any thriller can get hammy and boring. The challenge of keeping a viewer gripped is what excites me," she says. In the movie, the mother of two essays the role of Jasmeet Bhamra, a British-Indian detective who recently lost her child and is assigned the case of a murdered 10-year-old in Buckinghamshire. The project, which also sees chef Ranveer Brar in an interesting role, is Kareena's maiden production venture, alongside Ekta Kapoor.

*Jaane Jaan*, based on Keigo Higashino's 2005 novel *The Devotion of Suspect X*, was hotly anticipated. A number of factors may have compelled one of Bollywood's most glamorous stars to take the OTT plunge. "The kind of content we are all consuming, the fact that it was a Sujoy Ghosh project, that I would get to work with Jaideep [Ahlawat] and Vijay [Varma], and the fact that it was a genre that I am a huge fan of—all of these were compelling reasons for me," says Kareena."There was also the charm of working with Sujoy. The women characters in his films are just so impactful. I hope I could do that with Maya as well. I have wanted to work with Sujoy ever since he made *Kahaani* (2012). I think he aces the crime thriller genre. I was eager to not just work with Vijay and Jaideep, but also talk to them, understand how they do the phenomenal work they do."

*Jaane Jaan* producer Jay Shewakramani's quip on Kareena's eager approach emphasises how curious she was to dive into the experience. "The shoot in Kalimpong and Darjeeling was Kareena's first after Jeh's birth. He travelled with her, yet we didn't even once feel on the set that there was a child waiting for her! She is such a consummate professional. In the final days of the schedule, Saif and Taimur also joined in for a holiday."

On her part, Kareena confesses, "While I was excited, to be honest, I was also nervous. And my husband didn't really help, you know. See, I am an ac-



**In *The Buckingham Murders*, Kapoor plays a detective and mother who recently lost her child and is assigned the case of the murder of a 10-year-old**